

Hygiene with limited water

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Reserve safe water for drinking, food, medicines and essential hygiene. Wash hands with safe water and soap before food preparation and after toilet or waste handling. Keep clean and dirty tasks separate. Sanitiser with at least 60% alcohol helps when hands are not visibly dirty; it does not remove chemicals or replace washing dirty hands.

Do now.

- ☐ **Set up a clean station**
01 Put safe water, soap and a clean towel or air-drying arrangement near food and care tasks. Use a container that does not require everyone to dip dirty hands into the supply.
- ☐ **Prioritise key washing times**
02 Wash after toilet and waste handling, before eating or preparing food and before wound or infant care. Do not use suspected chemically contaminated water on skin.
- ☐ **Use sanitiser appropriately**
03 Use at least 60% alcohol sanitiser when soap and safe water are unavailable and hands are not visibly dirty. Keep it away from flames and children.
- ☐ **Separate waste and food**
04 Store rubbish and toilet waste away from water, food and sleeping areas. Clean high-contact surfaces using product instructions without mixing chemicals.
- ☐ **Plan personal care**
05 Include menstrual supplies, nappies, necessary skin care and clean clothing. Keep wounds clean and covered; worsening redness, pain or fever needs medical assessment.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the smallest workable clean-water station and protect it from contamination. Reduce nonessential washing before cutting drinking water or essential handwashing.

Watch for.

Surface disinfectant is not drinking-water treatment. Do not apply household bleach to skin or mix bleach with ammonia or other cleaners.

People & practical needs.

Make the hygiene plan usable for children, mobility needs and caregivers changing diapers or handling wounds. Keep gloves, cleaning tools and drinking-water supplies distinct. Tell everyone where the clean handwashing area is and who manages waste.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Replenish safe water when a verified source becomes available. Keep a routine that the household can sustain; a simple clean station is more useful than occasional improvised deep cleaning.

Check the next usable option

Replenish safe water when a verified source becomes available. Keep a routine that the household can sustain; a simple clean station is more useful than occasional improvised deep cleaning.

When the first option is unavailable

Use the smallest workable clean-water station and protect it from contamination. Reduce nonessential washing before cutting drinking water or essential handwashing.

Questions in the field.

How do I separate clean and dirty handling?

Choose a clean area for drinking water, food and medicine and a different area for waste and dirty tools. Make the clean-water container easy to identify. Use safe water and follow public-health guidance for handwashing after waste handling.

Can a temporary toilet go anywhere?

No. Local sanitation and disposal rules, soil, water sources and household access affect the plan. Keep waste away from drinking supplies and floodwater exposure. A temporary container must be stable, covered and managed without contaminating a living area.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

CDC · Personal hygiene during an emergency

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/safety/guidelines-for-personal-hygiene-during-an-emergency.html>

CDC · Emergency water

<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/emergency-hygiene/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.